



United Nations
Educational, Scientific and
Cultural Organization

Ref.: CL/4309

Subject: **10th consultation on the implementation of the 1960 Convention and Recommendation against Discrimination in Education**

Sir/Madam,

The right to education for all is one of the major challenges we face today.

So, ten years out from the target date for achieving the Education 2030 agenda as part of Sustainable Development Goal 4, some 258 million children and young people were still out of school worldwide in 2018.

The 1960 Convention and Recommendation against Discrimination in Education, major global normative instruments protecting the right to education, reflect UNESCO's mission which, according to its Constitution, is to "*advance the ideal of equality of educational opportunities without regard to race, sex or any distinctions, economic or social.*"

Under Article VIII of UNESCO's Constitution, Member States are required to submit regular reports on the measures they have taken to implement the conventions and recommendations adopted by the Organization.

We are therefore launching the tenth Consultation on the implementation of the 1960 Convention and Recommendation, and I invite your government to prepare a national report covering the 2017-2020 period. To assist your authorities in this regard, please find enclosed the **Guidelines for the preparation of reports**.

Please note that the Recommendation is monitored in conjunction with the Convention and the reporting obligation for both instruments is the same, therefore **all Member States**, including non-State Parties to the Convention, need to submit a report.

Member States are encouraged to organize the necessary consultations including with relevant civil society organizations and other key stakeholders.

The detailed arrangements for the submission of reports will be communicated to the Permanent Delegations to UNESCO.

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To Ministers responsible for relations with UNESCO

The report should be submitted **no later than 30 June 2020**, in order for the Secretariat to prepare an analytical global report and submit it to UNESCO's governing bodies in October and November 2021.

Please accept, Sir/Madam, the assurances of my highest consideration.

Audrey Azoulay
Director-General

Enclosures: 1

– Guidelines for preparation of national reports

cc: Permanent Delegations to UNESCO
National Commissions for UNESCO
Regional Offices
Field Offices

GUIDELINES FOR THE PREPARATION OF REPORTS BY MEMBER STATES ON THE APPLICATION OF THE 1960 CONVENTION AND RECOMMENDATION AGAINST DISCRIMINATION IN EDUCATION

Approved by UNESCO's Executive Board at its 207th session in October 2019

1. Introduction

The Convention against Discrimination in Education ("the Convention") and the Recommendation against Discrimination in Education ("the Recommendation"), adopted by UNESCO's General Conference in 1960, respond to UNESCO's constitutional mandate to "advance the ideal of equality of educational opportunities without regard to race, sex or any distinctions, economic or social". The Convention is the first legally binding international instrument providing for the **right to education** and the only one exclusively devoted to it.

The right to education is today one of the key principles underpinning the Education 2030 agenda and Sustainable Development Goal 4 (SDG 4) adopted by the international community. SDG 4 is rights-based and seeks to ensure the full enjoyment of the right to education as fundamental to achieving sustainable development. Its scope captures the multidimensional nature of the right to education.

The Convention has been recognized as a **cornerstone of Education 2030 agenda**. It also represents a powerful tool to advance SDG 4 by ensuring effective articulation between normative and operational work.

The present Guidelines are intended to assist Member States in the preparation of national reports on the implementation of the Convention as well as the Recommendation in the context of the 10th Consultation.

2. Reporting obligations

There are differences in the legal nature of the obligations under the Convention, as distinguished from those under the Recommendation. The Convention has binding force and the States Parties are obliged to incorporate its provisions into their national Constitution or domestic law. The Recommendation, non-binding in nature, has political and moral force. Its adoption sought to take into account the difficulties that certain states might experience, in particular on account of their federal structure, in ratifying the Convention.

Bearing in mind the differences in wording and in legal scope inherent to the nature of these two categories of instruments, the content of the Recommendation is identical to that of the Convention. Member States are expected to give effect to it in national legislation and education policies.

Most importantly, the reporting obligation under the provisions of Article VII of the Convention and of the Recommendation is the same. Article VIII of UNESCO's Constitution states that "*Each Member State shall submit to the Organization, at such times and in such manner as shall be determined by the General Conference, reports on the laws, regulations and statistics relating to its educational, scientific and cultural institutions and activities, and on the action taken upon the recommendations and conventions referred to in Article IV, paragraph 4*". Therefore, even if a country is not a State Party to the Convention, it needs to submit a report on the implementation of the Recommendation, which means that **all UNESCO Member States are expected to submit a national report** on the implementation of these instruments in the context of monitoring consultations.

3. Participation in consultations

In light of the Education 2030 agenda, the monitoring of the implementation of the Convention and the Recommendation is of crucial importance in order to ensure an education that is truly for all and to counter persistent inequalities in access, participation and learning outcomes at all levels, particularly for the most vulnerable groups. Concrete measures taken by Member States in accordance with their legal obligations under these instruments contribute to this process.

As the scope and content of the legal obligations under the right to education are aligned with the 10 targets of SDG 4 on education, efforts have also been made to ensure that the specific components are included in the guidelines and that the guidelines serve as a valuable monitoring tool for measuring progress towards SDG 4 targets.¹ In addition, in view of the educational challenges posed by the influxes of refugees and displacements worldwide, the guidelines provide the opportunity to report on concrete measures taken during the reporting period to include refugees and migrants in their educational systems. An emphasis is also to be placed on legal and policy framework that protects the rights of national minorities.

The reporting should be as comprehensive as possible and the process needs to be **participatory** and conducted in cooperation between ministries of education and other ministries dealing with aspects of the right to education. Relevant information from CSOs having education as their main field of activity should also be provided.

The preparation of national reports provides a **good opportunity** for Member States to assess the implementation of the right to education in their country, identify specific challenges, build constructive dialogue with other actors involved in this field and share good practices.

4. General indications

The reporting period for the 10th Consultation on the implementation of the Convention and the Recommendation covers four years (2017-2020).

Member States that already reported to the 9th Consultation (2016-2017) are invited to **refer to their reports** when appropriate. Relevant information supplied for other reporting instances may be reproduced or referred to with precise indication as to its retrieval. Similarly, hyperlinks to any useful documents or relevant legal and policy texts are most welcome and texts can also be added in the annex.

In the preparation of reports, Member States are kindly requested to provide brief and concise information, although they may provide details on the scope of the question if deemed necessary. In addition to a description of the constitutional, legislative, administrative and policy framework established for the implementation of the provisions guaranteed by the instruments, the information supplied by Member States should demonstrate how legal norms and practices comply with the Convention and the Recommendation.

5. Modalities

With a view to simplify the Guidelines while providing necessary substantive information to assist Member States in the preparation of responses, two series of questions/remarks are presented:

- (1) Open-ended and closed-ended questions to be directly filled in by Member States through a participatory process. Please note that multiple answers may be provided where relevant.
- (2) Additional information aimed at guiding Members States to structure and detail their responses to the open-ended questions (including remarks on how to respond efficiently to the questions raised). These elements are presented in *italics*.

In their responses, Member States are encouraged to provide information in a concise manner while preserving substantive and relevant content.

¹ Please note that the 1974 Recommendation concerning Education for International Understanding, Co-operation and Peace and Education relating to Human Rights and Fundamental Freedoms is used specifically for monitoring SDG target 4.7. The 1960 Convention and Recommendation contribute more generally to the body of evidence for monitoring the targets of SDG4.

GENERAL INFORMATION:

Country name: **CYPRUS**

Organization or entity responsible for the preparation of the report:

Ministry of Education, Culture, Sport and Youth

I. Information on the legislative, judicial, administrative and other measures taken by the state at the national level

1. Ratification of the Convention²

Is your country a State Party to the Convention?

☒ Yes

☐ No: Does your country plan to ratify this instrument?

☐ Yes: Please indicate the stage of ratification process reached by your country:

☐ Close to ratification

☐ Underway

☐ Actively under preparation

- Please briefly explain the difficulties encountered in completing the ratification process and the means of overcoming them:

Describe:

☐ *the obstacles, whether legal, institutional, political or practical*

☐ *the means of overcoming them and the extent to which UNESCO can assist in completing the process*

☐ No, not considering ratification in the near future. Please explain why:

² http://portal.unesco.org/en/ev.php-URL_ID=12949&URL_DO=DO_TOPIC&URL_SECTION=201.html

2. Ratification of the Protocol³ instituting a Conciliation and Good Offices Commission to be responsible for seeking the settlement of any disputes which may arise between States Parties to the Convention against Discrimination in Education

Has your country ratified the Protocol?

☒ Yes

☐ No, please briefly explain the difficulties encountered:

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3. Legal framework governing the protection of rights guaranteed in the Convention and the Recommendation in the national legal system

In case your country is a State Party to the Convention:

- Is the Convention directly applicable in your country's domestic law following its ratification?

☐ Yes ☐ No

- If not, has it been incorporated into the national Constitution or domestic law so as to be directly applicable?

☐ Yes ☐ No

This seeks information on whether the provisions of the Convention are guaranteed in a domestic legal instrument. The report should list the main legal texts (Constitution, legislative text or other provisions) adopted to guarantee the right to education for all and to promote equal educational opportunities. References, dates and aims could be provided.

The fundamental principles that govern the entire education system are outlined in Article 20 of the 1960 Constitution of the Republic of Cyprus which reads among others:

"Every person has the right to receive, and every person or institution has the right to give instruction or education, subject to such formalities, conditions or restrictions as are in accordance with the relevant communal law and are necessary only in the interests of the security of the Republic or the constitutional order or the public safety or the public order or the public health or the public morals or the standard and quality of education or for the protection of the rights and liberties of others including the right of the parents to secure for their children such education as is in conformity with their religious convictions".

The second and third paragraphs of this Article make reference to primary education as follows:

- *Free primary education shall be made available by the Greek and Turkish Communal Chambers in the respective communal primary schools.*

³ http://portal.unesco.org/en/ev.php-URL_ID=15321&URL_DO=DO_TOPIC&URL_SECTION=201.html

- *Primary education shall be compulsory for all citizens of such school age as may be determined by a relevant communal law.*

Law 24(I) of 1993 lays down the following provisions for education:

- *Attendance in primary school and lower secondary school (gymnasium) is compulsory until a pupil graduates from gymnasium or reaches the age of 15.*
- *Education is provided free of charge in public primary and secondary schools: gymnasium (lower-secondary), lyceum (upper-secondary) and technical schools.*
- *The textbooks published by the Ministry of Education are provided free of charge to teachers and pupils.*
- *The Council of Ministers has the authority to provide transport to pupils living at a distance from the school they attend; this is either subsidized or free of charge.*

- Have the provisions of the Convention been invoked before and given effect to by courts, tribunals and administrative authorities?

☐ Yes ☒ **No**

If yes, please illustrate on the basis of available case law and jurisprudence. Information could also be given about the judicial, administrative and other competent authorities having jurisdiction with respect to the rights guaranteed by the Convention and the scope of such competence.

In case your country is not a State Party to the Convention:

- Have legislative measures been taken pursuant to the Recommendation?

☐ Yes ☐ No

If yes, the report could list the main texts adopted to guarantee the right to education for all and to promote equal educational opportunities. References, dates and aims could be provided.

- Please explain briefly the extent to which public policies and programmes correspond to the general provisions of the Recommendation.

Information supplied could demonstrate how such policies and programmes comply with commitments of the right to education under the Recommendation.

II. Information on the implementation of the Convention or Recommendation

1. Non-discrimination and equal opportunities in education in the context of Sustainable Development Goal 4 (SDG4)

Articles/Paragraphs 1(1), 2 and 3 of the Convention/Recommendation provide for non-discrimination and equal opportunities in education. This part relates to the main purpose of the Convention/Recommendation that is to underscore the state obligation to proscribe any form of discrimination in education while promoting equality of educational opportunity.

*This corresponds to the overall aspiration of SDG4 which aims to “**ensure inclusive and equitable quality education and promote lifelong learning opportunities for all**” by 2030. It therefore covers all the SDG4 targets, but also specifically SDG target 4.5.⁴*

- 1.1 Please indicate measures adopted by your government to eliminate and prevent discrimination in education within the meaning of the Convention/Recommendation (please tick all that apply)⁵ (several items could be ticked/mentioned):

- ✓ Constitutional laws and/or legislation prohibit discrimination in education
- ✓ Regulations prohibit discrimination in education
- ✓ Policies and programmes aim to eliminate and prevent discrimination in education
- ✓ Access to justice in case of violations of the right to non-discrimination in education
- ✓ Combatting discrimination in terms of curriculum

Please provide a brief description of the relevant legal, regulatory or policy texts including measures on:

- ☐ *Non-discrimination in the admission of pupils to educational institutions*
- ☐ *Non-differential treatment, including of foreign nationals resident in your country*

⁴ Which calls on states to “eliminate gender disparities in education and ensure equal access to all levels of education and vocational training for the vulnerable, including persons with disabilities, indigenous peoples and children in vulnerable situations”.

⁵ See: Article/Paragraph 1(1)

The Ministry of Education, Culture, Sport and Youth (MOECSY) is committed towards preventing any form of discrimination based on race, sex, language, religion, color, sexual orientation or national origin, promoting various actions and activities. Through its three-year Strategic Plan for the period 2020-2022, the MOECSY is aiming to ensure the provision of learning opportunities to all learners, through the implementation of an educational policy which embodies the values of equality, inclusivity, creativeness and innovation. Its basic goal is to increase access to quality education and provide opportunities for all learners to become successful in their learning, through modernizing teaching methods and approaches, designing and implementing modern developmental programmes and creating the infrastructure that can facilitate high quality education.

In addition, the MOECSY has designed and developed the **National Strategy for Preventing and addressing School Violence**, which has a four-year time-frame of implementation. The Strategy's areas include: a) creation of information systems regarding the extent and forms of violence in schools, b) design and implementation of legislative and administrative measures for child-protection, c) empowerment of parents, educators and principals, d) training of children in positive and nonviolent behaviors, e) child participation in the development and implementation of policies and measures and f) development of an inter-disciplinary model of services.

More specifically, an antiracist policy «Code of Conduct against Racism & Guide for Managing and Recording Racist Incidents» is being implemented with the support of the Cyprus Pedagogical Institute (CPI) since the school year 2014-2015. The development and implementation of the policy responds to the European Commission's against Racism and Intolerance guideline No 10 (1 ECRI General Policy Recommendation No 10 on Combating Racism and Racial Discrimination in and Through School Education (Adopted On 15 December 2006), Strasbourg, 21 March 2007) and is also in line with various international and European conventions that Cyprus has ratified. The policy outlines the responsibilities and commitments, expected by each member of the school community, and provides the steps to be followed by schools for dealing with racist incidents in a practical rubric.

Since 2016, the CPI provides support to schools in order to implement the antiracist policy, through various ways, with seminars, conferences, through the creation of School Network across Cyprus, etc.

Additionally, the Cyprus Observatory on School Violence (COSV) of the Pedagogical Institute has developed and implemented actions that aim to prevent and address bullying and violence in schools. COSV provides support to school units for the implementation of actions and programs aimed at improving the school climate, reducing violence in schools and combating bullying.

1.2 Please indicate actions taken by your government to guarantee equal access to all levels and types of education in your country (several items could be ticked/mentioned):

- ☒ Constitutional laws and/or legislation guarantee equal access to education
- ☒ Regulations ensure equal access to all levels and types of education
- ☐ Policies and programmes ensure equal access to all levels and types of education
- ☒ Other:

Education in public schools is focused on the acceptance of difference, tolerance as well as the respect for other cultures so as to prepare tomorrow's citizens for living in a multicultural environment. Towards this end, the MOECSY gives great emphasis on ensuring equal access to

education for all children living on the island, taking into account that the right to education is safeguarded in the Convention on the Rights of the Child as well as in the Constitution of the Republic of Cyprus. The fact that primary and secondary education is compulsory up to the age of fifteen, and provided free of charge by the Government to all, irrespective of the residential status of the pupils' parents, and that primary and secondary schools are established and functioning in all towns and in rural areas, safeguards the right of pupils to full access to different levels of education. Failure to enrol a pupil belonging in the abovementioned age group at an educational institution (public or private) will result in the prosecution of the legal guardian. All necessary measures are taken so that effective access to basic education for all is guaranteed. During the period under review a systematic effort has been made to increase access to education for all children and strengthen the quality of the education provided.

- Please indicate the relevant legal, regulatory or policy texts and provide a brief description of the measures taken:

This notably is covered under SDG target 4.1 and partly target 4.b⁶

1.3 Please indicate the actions taken and planned in your country to ensure equality of opportunities (in terms of access, participation and completion), equal treatment and to support the inclusion of all learners (including girls and women, the economically and socially marginalized, people with disabilities and other vulnerable groups) in learning processes (several items could be ticked/mentioned):

- | | |
|--|--|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> ☒ Providing financial incentives and fellowships ☐ Providing positive or affirmative action measures ☒ Ensuring inclusion in mainstream schools for all learners ☒ Training teachers on inclusive education ☒ Ensuring gender parity in science, technology, engineering and mathematics (STEM) and technical and vocational training (TVET) ☒ Providing re-entry programmes for young mothers ☒ Eliminating all barriers for pregnant girls or young mothers in education ☐ Other: | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> ☐ Providing auxiliary assistance ☒ Adapting education infrastructure ☒ Adapting curricula and methods ☒ Providing language classes to newcomers (e.g. refugees) ☐ Eliminating administrative barriers to education⁷ ☒ Providing flexible learning pathways ☒ Valuing diversity in schools ☒ Combatting stereotyping and stigmatization |
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⁶ Which calls on states to "substantially expand globally the number of scholarships available [...] for enrolment in higher education, including vocational training and information and communications technology, technical, engineering and scientific programmes".

⁷ Administrative barriers to education include, amongst others, lack of identity papers or birth certificates required to enrol.

In keeping with current philosophy, the MOECSY favours the inclusion of children with disabilities in mainstream classrooms. The majority of children with disabilities are educated within the mainstream classroom, at their local school. Cyprus has ratified the Convention on the Rights of Disabilities and promotes the respect and protection of human rights and fundamental freedoms of all persons with disabilities without discrimination of any kind. Special emphasis is given to ensuring curriculum access with the use of assistive technology (computers, specialized software, tablets, joysticks and tracker balls, easy-to-use keyboards, communication devices), changes to teaching and learning arrangements, classroom organisation, extra time during exams etc. Furthermore, information that is normally provided in writing is made more accessible by providing it in Braille or in large print for children with visual disability, whereas sign language interpreters are available for deaf children. The MOECSY ensures that schools have suitable infrastructure to accommodate the needs of pupils with disabilities. Schools increase access for individual pupils by making various adjustments. Changes to the physical environment that schools make to increase access include: lighting and paint schemes to help children with visual disabilities, lifts and ramps to help children with physical disabilities or carpeting of classrooms to help children with hearing disabilities. The MOECSY also provides schools with special equipment, such as wheelchairs and walking aids. In addition, it provides for transportation to all children who do not attend the school of their educational district.

Special educational provision is also provided in Special Units within mainstream schools, as well as in Special Schools. A very small percentage of children with disabilities (less than 1% of the school population) are educated in Special Units. Special Units provide more intensive educational support to a small number of pupils in a class, whilst maintaining contact and integration with a specific reference class of the school, following the regular curriculum in specific subjects. Special Schools also have pre-vocational and vocational training programmes designed to assist the transition from school to work or from school to other vocational training authorities.

Currently, the MOECSY is receiving technical assistance from the Directorate General for Structural Reform Support (DG REFORM) of the European Commission and, in cooperation with experts from the European Agency of Special Needs and Inclusive Education, is in the process of reforming the existing law of Special Education, so that the education system becomes more efficient and inclusive. The experts have submitted a new draft framework law which was discussed with all stakeholders and now the project is in its second phase, for the preparation of regulations that will accompany the law.

- Please elaborate further on the measures taken, including those to ensure gender equality and the empowerment of girls and women in and through education:

The MOECSY is focused on ensuring equal opportunities in education for both genders on a non-discriminatory basis at all levels of education. Therefore, it has formed an Interdepartmental Committee that coordinates all gender equality issues related to actions by developing an Action Plan. The Plan is being implemented through training courses, workshops, conferences school competitions and teaching material posted on a website.

In addition, the MOECSY implements sexuality education based on the World Health Organization guidelines, through the introduction of **Health Education Curriculum** since 2011. The topics that relate to sexuality education in the Health Education Curriculum are mostly included in the thematic unit 3.1: Family Planning, Sexual and Reproductive Health. Sexuality education, as included in Health Education, may contribute to the prevention and dealing of social problems such as sexual violence, bullying, unwanted pregnancies in teenagers, trafficking, homophobia, risky sexual behaviors, HIV/AIDS and other STDs, reproduction of gender stereotypes, violence against women, stigmatization and discrimination of marginalized groups such as LGBT students etc.*

* WHO-Europe and Federal Centre for Health Education BZgA, (2010).Standards for sexuality in Europe.A framework for policy makers, educational and health authorities and specialists. Cologne: WHO Europe and Federal Centre for Health Education BZgA <http://www.bzga-whocc.de/?uid=072bde22237db64297daf76b7cb998f0&id=Seite4486>

- Please indicate whether your country has adopted and reviewed legislation related to the minimum age for marriage so that it conforms to international standards (18 years):

Please note that child marriage is a discriminatory practice as often girls can marry at a younger age than boys. Child marriage violates the child's right to education as they are more likely to drop out of school and children who are not in school are more likely to get married.

✓ Yes

No

Please provide reference to the relevant laws and provisions:

Under Marriage Law 2003 the legal minimum age of marriage is 18 years. However, marriage is permitted over the age of 16 years with consent of parents or guardians. Cyprus has committed to eliminate child, early and forced marriage by 2030 in line with target 5.3 of the Sustainable Development Goals. Cyprus co-sponsored the 2017 Human Rights Council resolution recognizing the need to address child, early and forced marriage in humanitarian contexts, and the 2015 Human Rights Council resolution to end

child, early and forced marriage, recognizing that it is a violation of human rights. Cyprus co-sponsored the 2013 and 2014 UN General Assembly resolutions on child, early and forced marriage, and the 2013 Human Rights Council resolution on child, early and forced marriage. In 2014, Cyprus signed a joint statement at the Human Rights Council calling for a resolution on child marriage. Cyprus ratified the Convention on the Rights of the Child in 1991, which sets a minimum age of marriage of 18, and acceded to the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women (CEDAW) in 1985, which obligates states to ensure free and full consent to marriage. At the London Girl Summit in July 2014, the government signed a charter committing to end child marriage by 2020.

2. Progress made with respect to implementing the right to education in the context of SDG 4

2.1 Pre-primary education

Pre-primary education is not explicitly provided for in the Convention/Recommendation. However, the international community has increasingly recognized the importance of early childhood care and education (ECCE) over the years. The Committee on the Rights of the Child initially recognized “the right to education during early childhood as beginning at birth” (General Comment 7). This became more explicit with the 2010 Moscow Framework for Action and Cooperation⁸. In the current context of the Education 2030 agenda, under SDG target 4.2, states have now committed to “the provision of at least one year of free and compulsory pre-primary education”.

- Is compulsory and free of charge pre-primary education available in your country?

✓Pre-primary education is compulsory: Please provide the age of enrolment and duration:

Pre-primary education is compulsory for children aged 4 years and 8 months. The duration of compulsory pre-primary education is 1 year and 4 months. Since 2021-2022, children will move from pre-primary to primary education at the age of 6.

✓Pre-primary education is free of charge for all: Please provide the duration:

Pre-primary education is free of charge for all children of compulsory age, who attend public kindergartens. The duration of free of charge pre-primary education is 1 year and 4 months.

- Please list the laws and policies that ensure the availability of pre-primary education for all and provide information on the difficulties experienced by your government in the realization of access to pre-primary education. Brief quantitative information could be added.

⁸ Which states that “ECCE is part of the right to education and the main foundation for holistic human development”.

Some of the policies that ensure the availability of pre-primary education for all are:

- Allocation of vacant places: When the registration of all children of compulsory pre-primary education is completed, any vacant places are allocated to younger children (aged 3 to 4 years and 8 months). The allocation of the places is based on specific criteria approved by the Council of Ministers. Younger children aged 3 to 4 years and 8 months who are enrolled in public kindergartens pay a fee of EUR 42, per child, per month. According to the revised criteria, priority is now given to children at risk and socioeconomic deprivation.*
- All-day optional public kindergartens: In order to support parents' employment opportunities, all-day optional public kindergartens function until 16:00, on an optional basis.*
- Community kindergartens: The MOECSY subsidizes, with an annual grant, local authorities, Parents' Associations of public pre-primary schools, Community Welfare Boards, Trade Unions, or Charity Boards, for the establishment and operation of community kindergartens. Due to the subsidized grants, community schools offer quality educational programmes with low fees. Community kindergartens operate only in cases where the public kindergarten classes available do not meet the needs of all the children aged 3 to 4 years and 8 months old, in the community.*

Some of the difficulties experienced regarding access to pre-primary education is the lack of available places in public kindergartens for the enrolment of children of non-compulsory education (3 years to 4 years and 8 months old). Around 50% of the applicants each year are not granted a place in public kindergarten schools. The only option available for this group of children regarding access to pre-primary education is the private sector, which charges a high amount of tuition fees, an average of 200-250 euros per month.

2.2 Universal primary and secondary education

Article/Paragraph 4(a) of the Convention/Recommendation provides for universal primary and secondary education. In the context of the Education 2030 agenda, SDG target 4.1 calls on States to provide “12 years of free, publicly funded, inclusive, equitable, quality primary and secondary education – of which at least nine years are compulsory.”

Primary education

- Is primary education compulsory in your country?

✓Yes ☐No

Please indicate the current duration period of compulsory education and the age of enrolment:

In this part, you may also provide information on the difficulties experienced by your government in the realization of universal access to primary education. Quantitative information could be added.

The duration of compulsory primary education is 6 years (6 grades). For the school year 2020-2021, pupils will be enrolled in primary education at the age of 5 years and 10 months old and from 2021-2022 onwards, pupils will be enrolled at the age of 6 years old.

- Is primary education available free of charge to all?

✓Yes: Please provide the duration and indicate the extent to which it is.

For this, please list the laws and policies that ensure the universal and free availability of primary education and indicate whether direct and indirect costs are charged (such as tuition fees, exam fees, schools supplies, uniforms, transport costs and compulsory levies on parents).

"The Compulsory and Free Education at Primary and Secondary Level Law (N. 24(I)/1993", amended by Law 220(I)/2004 and by Law 1(I)/2019

The Law 24(I)/1993 and its amendments provide for free education at the primary and secondary levels and compulsory education at primary and lower secondary levels. Parents or guardians of children, who fail to register and send them to school during the specified period, are subject to legal penalties. The Law also provides for stationery and the textbooks to be published by the Ministry of Education, Culture, Sport and Youth to be provided to teachers and pupils free of charge. It also assigns to the Council of Ministers the authority to decide for provision of transport, either subsidized or free of charge, to pupils living at a distance from the school they attend.

- ☐ No: Is your country already engaged in legal and policy reforms to work towards universal and free primary education?

☐ Yes ☐ No

- Please briefly provide information on the reforms taken:

Secondary education

In this part, please provide information on the general availability and accessibility to all of secondary education, including technical and vocational secondary education and training in your country.

- Is secondary education (middle/high) available free of charge?

✓ Yes: Please provide the duration and describe the extent to which it is.

Secondary Education is available free of charge. There is an option for private schools where there are tuition fees.

Attendance in public schools is free for all students between the age of 4 years and 8 months to 18 years. Textbooks are given to both students and teachers free of charge. All exam fees and school supplies are also provided by the government, free of charge to the students.

Uniforms and transport costs are undertaken by the students.

*The relevant laws and provisions can be found on the following website:
<http://www.moec.gov.cy/dme/nomothesia.html>*

Please list the laws and policies that ensure the free availability of secondary education and describe whether direct and indirect costs are covered (such as tuition fees, exam fees, school supplies, uniforms, transport costs and compulsory levies on parents).

- ☐ No: What are the measures your government intends to take to ensure free secondary education?

- Is secondary education (middle/high) compulsory in your country?

✓ Yes ☐ No

- Please provide details on its implementation and indicate the duration of compulsory secondary education and the age of enrolment:

In this part, you may also provide information on the difficulties experienced by your government in the realization of universal access to secondary education. Quantitative

information could be added.

Secondary education is compulsory until the age of 15 years (end of lower secondary education/ middle school).

Lower secondary education is provided in the lower secondary education schools/middle schools (called Gymnasio) and it comprises a three- year course of general education, beginning at the age of 11 years and 8 months.

Upper secondary education is not compulsory and involves a three-year cycle which begins at the age of 15 years and is offered in two different types of programs:

- *The upper secondary general education programs.*
- *The upper secondary technical and vocational education programs.*

The upper secondary general education schools are called lyceums (Lykeia) and their programs include both core and optional subjects.

Secondary technical and vocational education (STVE) is offered in the technical schools (Technikes scholes). The STVE programs include formal technical and vocational education offered in two streams - the theoretical stream and the practical stream.

- Indicate whether your country has adopted and reviewed legislation related to the minimum age of entry into employment so that it is aligned with the end of compulsory education:

Please note that minimum age labour laws and those related to compulsory education interdependent and mutually reinforce each other. If the minimum age of employment is below that of compulsory education, the child is at risk of dropping out of school to work and therefore not completing compulsory education. On the other hand, if compulsory education is lower than the minimum age of employment, once the child has completed compulsory education, the door is open to child exploitation and the violation of labour laws.

✓Yes

No ☐

- Please provide reference to the relevant laws and provisions:

Young people from 15 to 18 years of age may work up to seven hours per day. If they also attend school, there should be a two-hour break between their job and their study hours. They are not allowed to work overtime or from 23:00 to 07:00.

*The relevant laws and provisions can be found on the following website:
<http://www.cyprus.gov.cy/portal/portal.nsf/qwp.getGroup?OpenForm&access=0&SectionId=government&CategoryId=Legislations&SelectionId=Laws%20regarding%20Work&print=0&lang=en>*

2.3 Higher education

Article/Paragraph 4(a) of the Convention/Recommendation provides for higher education. Ensuring higher education is essential to achieve SDG4, both targets 4.3⁹, and target 4.4¹⁰.

- Please indicate the measures adopted to ensure that there is no discrimination on the grounds prohibited by the Convention/Recommendation¹¹ to enter and complete higher education, including technical and vocational education and training (several items could be ticked/mentioned):

✓ Constitutional laws and/or legislation prohibit discrimination in higher education, including technical and vocational education and training.

✓ Regulations prohibit discrimination in higher education, including technical and vocational education and training

✓ Policies and programs aim to eliminate and prevent discrimination in higher education, including technical and vocational education and training

☐ Other:

- Please provide a brief description of the relevant legal, regulatory or policy texts including measures on:

☐ ☐ *Non-discrimination in the admission of students to higher education institutions on the grounds prohibited by the Convention/Recommendation*

☐ ☐ *Non-differential treatment, including of foreign students*

- *The Pancyprian Examinations Law 22 (I)/2006*
- *The Overseas Positions in the Public Universities of Cyprus, Regulations 266/2009*
- *The Student Welfare Law 203 (I)/2015*

- Please indicate efforts made by your government to ensure that higher education is equally accessible to all on the basis of individual capacity and/or is available free of charge (several items could be ticked/mentioned):

Article 4 of the Convention requires states to make “higher education equally accessible to all on the basis of individual capacity”. Article 13 of the International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights, further adds that this should be pursued by “every appropriate means, and in particular by the progressive introduction of free education”.

✓ Higher education is generally free of charge

✓ Higher education is accessible on the basis of individual capacity as assessed by reference to relevant qualifications and experience

✓ Higher education is accessible through financial incentives and scholarships

⁹ Which calls on states to “ensure equal access for all women and men to affordable and quality technical, vocational and tertiary education, including university”.

¹⁰ Which recommends to “substantially increase the number of youth and adults who have relevant skills, including technical and vocational skills, for employment, decent jobs and entrepreneurship”.

¹¹ See: Article/Paragraph 1(1).

- ✓Higher education is accessible through positive or affirmative action measures
- ✓Higher education is accessible through credit transfer system between states
- ✓Other:

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- Please elaborate on the measures taken and provide brief information on the financial costs to receive education in higher public or private education institutions, if higher education is not free of charge.

In this part, you may also provide information on the difficulties experienced by your government as regards access to higher education and on the progress realized. Quantitative information could be added.

Public Higer Education is free of charge for all at the undergraduate level. Private Institutions of Higer Education have fees but they also offer a number of scholarships (partial or full) to students with financial problems. The State also offers grants to students, based on economic and social criteria.

2.4 Adult education and alternative learning

Article/Paragraph 4(c) of the Convention/Recommendation provides for adult education and alternative learning. While SDG4 aims to “ensure inclusive and equitable quality education and promote lifelong learning opportunities for all”, target 4.6 specifically calls on states to “ensure that all youth and a substantial proportion of adults, both men and women, achieve literacy and numeracy”. Furthermore, under target 4.4, states are called “to increase and diversify learning opportunities, using a wide range of education and training modalities, so that all youth and adults, especially girls and women, can acquire relevant knowledge, skills and competencies for decent work and life.”

- Please indicate the efforts made by your government to establish a system of continuing education and equitable access to learning and training opportunities (several items could be ticked/mentioned):

- ✓ Provision of education for persons who have not received or completed the whole period of their primary education
- ✓ Provision of literacy programmes
- ✓ Provision of appropriate learning and life-skills programmes
- ✓ Provision of free of charge learning opportunities
- ✓ Provision of flexible learning pathways
- ✓ Provision of professional training and qualifications
- ✓ Other:

A collection of laws along with many other provisions aim to securing satisfactory levels of education for adult learners in Cyprus. The Ministry of Education, Culture, Sport and Youth (MoECSY) provides a variety of programmes that fall within the formal and non-formal spectrum and cover both the general adult education as well as the continuing Vocational Education and Training sector. The vast majority of the provided programmes are held in afternoon or evening hours in educational institutes based on urban as well as in rural areas.

These programmes aim to develop the social, personal, language and professional skills of the adults, enabling them to enter (or re-enter) the labour market or to enhance their personal attainment and fulfilment. Programmes also provide (young) adults the opportunity to complete their ISCED 3 studies, by being awarded the secondary school leaving certificate (equivalent to the morning general secondary or technical certificate). Most of the adult education programmes are state-run, therefore, participation in some of them is free of charge (especially for adults coming from vulnerable social groups such as prisoners, migrants, senior citizens, people with disabilities, illiterate people and early school leavers) in an effort to encourage participation, while in a number of other programmes the fee is extremely small (50 – 200 euros for a whole school year).

Although literacy programmes are provided to a rather limited extent, it is foreseen that the new Lifelong Learning Strategy (2021-2027) will serve as a means for a better coordination of the adult learning sector and also for better addressing basic skills, such as literacy, numeracy and digital skills of low skilled and low qualified adults. The implementation of a variety of learning opportunities is foreseen to enrich knowledge, skills and competences for personal development and economic well-being of the target groups.

Early school leavers in Cyprus can attend Evening Schools (General Evening Schools and General Evening Technical Schools). Their function is based on the principles and priorities of Adult Education and aims to provide basic and compensatory education, which will contribute to integration and reintegration of adult learners into social, cultural and economic life.

- Please elaborate further on the measures taken:

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2.5 Quality education provision and learning environment

Articles/Paragraphs 2, 4(b) and 5(b) of the Convention/Recommendation provide for quality education. Quality education is fundamental to achieve all targets of SDG4. It is also particularly highlighted in SDG target 4.a that recommends states to “build and upgrade education facilities that are child, disability and gender sensitive and provide safe, non-violent, inclusive and effective learning environments for all”.

- Please indicate the measures taken by your country to ensure equivalence in all educational institutions with regard to (several items could be ticked/mentioned):

- ✓ Establishment of minimum norms and standards in education
- ✓ Establishment of conditions relating to the quality of the education provided (e.g. infrastructure, learner/teacher ratios, teaching and learning materials, use of ICT)
- ✓ Adoption of legal or regulatory provisions to ensure that children learn in a safe environment free from violence or harassment, including school-related gender-based violence (in and around schools).

- Please elaborate further on the measures taken:

To provide such quality assessment, please take into account all educational institutions of the same level. You may include information on policies, protocols or codes of conduct.

The Cyprus Agency of Quality Assurance and Accreditation in Higher Education (CYQAA) is responsible for ensuring the quality of higher education in Cyprus and for supporting the continuous improvement and upgrading of higher education institutions (HEIs) and their programs of study through the procedures provided by the relevant legislation.

The Ministry of Education, Culture, Sport and Youth with the collaboration of the Cyprus Pedagogical Institute (CPI) has implemented the “Code of Conduct against Racism and Guide for Managing and Recording Racist Incidents”. The antiracist policy was developed at 2014 and it is based on the Follow- up Report of Cyprus for Recommendation No 20 and Recommendation by the Anti- Discrimination Body.

In addition, the MoECSY has designed and developed the National Strategy for Preventing and addressing School Violence, which has a four- year timeframe of implementation.

2.6 Education personnel

Article/Paragraph 4(d) of the Convention/Recommendation provides for the education personnel. This corresponds to SDG target 4.c which is entirely devoted to the teaching profession as it calls on states to “substantially increase the supply of qualified teachers”.

- Please indicate the measures taken to improve the teaching and working conditions of education personnel, especially teaching staff at all levels in your country and regarding the training for the teaching profession (several items could be ticked/mentioned):

- ✓ Teachers' average salaries are competitive or at least comparable to those paid in other professions requiring similar or equivalent qualifications (at all levels)
- ✓ Initial training and continuous professional development is provided
- ☐ Minimum standards and qualifications are required for the teaching profession
- ☐ Measures taken to strengthen the social status and attractiveness of the teaching profession
- ☐ Performance monitoring systems
- ☐ Measures taken to increase women in leadership positions in education
- ☐ Other:

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- Please briefly elaborate further on the measures taken:

All teachers are required to be university degree holders. The Cyprus Pedagogical Institute (CPI) is the official department of MOECSY which runs the professional learning of teachers. In the context of the professional learning policy implementation, every school in Cyprus must develop and implement an action plan regarding the professional learning of its staff and the improvement of the school. Each action plan includes the topic that schools decided to focus on, their specific goals and the trainings needed for the implementation of that plan.

- Have there been instances of discrimination as regards the training for education personnel in your country?

☐ Yes: Has your government addressed this issue?

☐ Yes

☐ No

✓No

2.7 Respect for human rights and fundamental freedoms

Article/Paragraph 5(1)(a) of the Convention/Recommendation provides for the respect for human rights and fundamental freedoms. This is covered under SDG target 4.7.¹² Please note that this section contributes to the general monitoring of Article/Paragraph 5(1)(a) of the Convention/Recommendation and that the consultation on the 1974 Recommendation concerning Education for International Understanding, Co-operation and Peace and Education relating to Human Rights and Fundamental Freedoms will be used specifically for monitoring SDG4 indicator 4.7.1.

- Please indicate the national efforts taken in directing education to the full development of the human personality and the strengthening of respect for human rights and fundamental freedoms (several items could be ticked/mentioned):

✓Curriculum includes human rights education

✓Educational and/or extracurricular activities are organized on human rights education

✓Other:

The Health Education Curriculum (HEC) of the MOECSY and the learning objectives include clearly defined success indicators related to issues concerning human rights education. More particularly, the success indicators of HEC include indicators associated with intimidating behavior, violence, social identities/gender development. Additionally, the curriculum includes success indicators relating to respect for diversity.

¹² Which calls on states to “ensure that all learners acquire the knowledge and skills needed to promote sustainable development, including, among others, through education for sustainable development and sustainable lifestyles, human rights, gender equality, promotion of a culture of peace and non-violence, global citizenship and appreciation of cultural diversity and of culture’s contribution to sustainable development”.

2.8 Private education

Articles/Paragraphs 2(c) and 5(1)(b) of the Convention/Recommendation provide for private education.

- Does your country have a regulatory framework relating to the establishment and functioning of private educational institutions?

✓ Yes

No

- Please provide a brief description:

Private Universities operate under the Private Universities (Establishment, Operation and Control) Law 109/2005 and Private Higher Education Institutions operates under the Institutions of Tertiary Education Laws 67(1)/1996.

Private Schools law of 2019.

- Do legal provisions prohibiting discrimination on the grounds listed by the Convention/Recommendation¹³ explicitly apply to private educational institutions?

✓ Yes

No

- Please briefly describe what laws, regulations or policies guarantee that the development of private education does not generate discrimination and that private schools offer a relevant alternative in your country:

Internal Regulations of Higher Education Institutions

The only requirement for attending private schools in Cyprus is to succeed at the entrance exams which are organized by each school. Every private school in Cyprus has tuition fees.

- Does your country have an education policy framework for minimum educational standards as regards the rights of the parents /legal guardians for providing religious and moral education for their children?

✓ Yes

No

2.9 Rights of national minorities

Article/Paragraph 5(1)(c) of the Convention/Recommendation provides for the rights of national minorities. National minorities, who often face language barriers, are among the specific groups referred to in the Convention.

- Please indicate the legal, policy and regulatory measures that protect the rights given to

¹³ See: Article/Paragraph 1(1).

national minorities to carry out their own educational activities (several items could be ticked/mentioned):

- ✓ Constitutional laws and/or legislation protect the right to education of national minorities
- ☐ Legislation or regulations guarantee the right of national minorities to study in their mother tongue
- ☐ Curriculum is adapted to national minority needs
- ☐ Teachers are trained to adapt to national minority needs
- ☐ Other:

- Please provide a brief description of the provisions:

According to the 1960 Constitution of the Republic of Cyprus, all Cypriot citizens are declared as belonging to either the Greek or to the Turkish Community. The term national minority, is understood to designate the following minority groups of citizens of the Republic of Cyprus, that is the Armenian, Maronite and Latin (Roman Catholic) hereafter referred to as religious groups. The three religious groups are composed of citizens of the Republic of Cyprus who at the time of establishment of the Republic of Cyprus in 1960 opted in accordance with its Constitution to be part of the Greek Community (Article 2, paragraph 3 of the Constitution).

The right of education for all children is safeguarded by Article 20 of the Constitution of the Republic of Cyprus. Moreover, the equality of all the children enrolled in schools is guaranteed by the legislation. The new regulations for the operation of public secondary schools that were issued in February 2017 clearly state that any person or public authority involved in the interpretation or implementation of the regulations is obliged to refrain from “any discrimination based on race, colour, gender, language, religion, political and other beliefs of the child or his/her parents or guardians, citizenship, ethnic or social origin, economic situation, disability, birth, sexual orientation or any other situation”.

The rights of the religious groups for carrying out their own educational activities are protected, supported and preserved by the Republic of Cyprus amongst others, through the ratification and implementation of two Conventions: the Framework Convention for the protection of National Minorities and the implementation of the Convention for the Protection of Minority Languages.

The Ministry of Education, Culture, Youth and Sports (MOECSY) strives to meet the needs of the members of the religious groups and to ensure that their educational and cultural rights are safeguarded and are fully exercised.

1. *The Educational Reform of the curricula for the subjects of History and Religious Education that were enriched with units and success indicators regarding the history, culture, language, religion and identity of the religious groups. In the subject of History, in particular, the curriculum contains proposed activities for the designing of projects by students and a list of monuments is included for the organisation of planned visits by the teachers, thus promoting the better understanding of the history of the religious groups in Cyprus. Additionally, the curriculum specifically mentions that through the teaching of history students are expected to develop respect for religious and cultural differences.*
2. *The protection of the right to carry out their own educational activities in public and private schools through the operation of their own schools, or through financial support by the Government in order to attend private schools of their choice. Thus, children belonging to the three religious groups have the right to be educated according to their potentialities and their parents' wishes and a number of other measures have been adopted for their smooth integration in the educational system.*

- As regards the educational standards in educational institutions run by minorities, please describe the existing legal and policy framework:

Information could also cover the language facilities, such as the availability of teaching in the mother tongue of the students, use of teaching of languages in education policy, multilingualism, etc.

Public Schools

- **Nareg Schools:**

The educational needs of children belonging to the Armenian religious group are supported through the operation of the Armenian Nareg schools. Nareg schools are fully subsidized by MOECSY. Additionally, the Armenian school board receives an annual contribution of €1 million by the MOECSY (please note this contribution includes part of their payroll.) The curriculum of Nareg schools is adapted to the needs of the Armenian religious group. Following, the recognition of the Armenian Language as one of the minority languages of the Republic of Cyprus, through the ratification of the Convention for the Protection of Minority Languages, the language is taught to the students attending Nareg schools. Moreover, the schools promote the Armenian identity and culture as an integral part of modern Cyprus society by teaching the Armenian history, geography and

religion as well as extra-curriculum activities, for example, Armenian dances and music lessons. The MOECSY also supports the organisation of training seminars for teachers of the Armenian Language as well as for the rest of the staff of the schools in order to adapt to the educational needs of the Armenian religious group.

- **Agios Maronas Primary School**

The educational needs of children belonging to the Maronite religious group are supported through the operation of Agios Maronas Primary school that operates as an optional all-day school. Agios Maronas Primary school is fully subsidized by MOECSY. Additionally, the Maronite School Board receives an annual contribution of €90,000 to cover the running cost and MOECSY subsidizes the transportation of Maronite children to the school. The curricula that are implemented in the school are enriched with issues associated with Maronites' history and culture, the Maronite catholic religion and geography and are applicable for all grades from first to the sixth. Curricula were modified following the underlining theory of enriching the educational context, while at the same time the school serves the educational objectives as they are stated in the curriculum followed by all Elementary Schools in Cyprus.

Following, the recognition of the Cypriot Maronite Arabic (CMA) as one of the minority languages of the Republic of Cyprus, through the ratification of the Convention for the Protection of Minority Languages, CMA is taught as an optional course during the afternoon timetable. CMA is also taught in the Adult Education Centres and the Annual Summer Language Camp for young Maronites in the village of Kormakitis. MOECSY also runs by phases a research program targeting the revitalization and safeguard of CMA with the implementation of an Action Plan, since 2013. The objectives of the Action Plan lay on: ethnographic work for the enrichment of the Archive of Oral Tradition with new material, emphasize on the production of teaching material and the training of native speakers. Teaching material for children level A1 based on the Common European Framework of Reference is completed and teaching material for children at level A2-B1 is under preparation. The MOECSY also supports the organisation of training seminars for teachers at Agios Maronas Primary School in order to adapt to the educational needs of the Maronite religious group.

Private schools

- *The MOECSY subsidizes the tuition fees of children belonging to the religious groups that choose to attend private schools at all levels. The subsidization is higher for Maronite, Armenian and Latin children that choose to attend the Terra Santa College and St' Marys School, private schools that are considered to be 'Ethnic Schools' for the religious groups.*
- *The Terra Santa College is also subsidized with the amount of €17.100 annually and Saint Mary school receives €25.945 as per the 30 May 2002 Council of Ministers Decision No. 55.709.*

2.10 Rights of refugees and migrants

The rights of refugees and migrants are not explicitly provided for in the Convention/Recommendation. However, the Convention and Recommendation call on states to eliminate and prevent discrimination in education based notably on national origin.¹⁴ In this context, a number of Member States that participated in the 9th Consultation reported on measures adopted to ensure refugees' and migrants' right to education. Growing displacement and influx of refugees worldwide and the emergence of major educational challenges in this area, as well as the frameworks recently adopted by the international community,¹⁵ demonstrate the opportunity for states to report on measures adopted to include refugees and migrants in their educational systems.

Besides, this aspect also corresponds to SDG target 4.5, which calls on states to “ensure equal access to all levels of education and vocational training for the vulnerable”, including “children in vulnerable situations”, and covers the majority of SDG 4 targets.

- Please briefly describe the existing legal and policy framework that protects the right to quality education for refugees and migrants in your country.

The MOECSY wishing to support the quick integration of children with a migrant background in the school community, starting in the school year 2008-2009, has been running a program for the intensive teaching of Greek as a second language. This program has been implemented by a decision of the Council of Ministers (July 29, 2008).

The MOECSY has recently developed and implemented an upgraded educational policy pertaining to Multicultural Education, aiming at the smooth integration of pupils with background into the educational system of Cyprus. The policy document was approved by the Minister of Education and Culture and the departments of the MOECSY have developed an action plan with a variety of targeted actions, through the prism of an intercultural approach, anti-racist education and the methodology of teaching Greek as a second language. The policy focuses

¹⁴ Articles/Paragraphs 1 and 3.

¹⁵ Namely the 2016 New York Declaration for Refugees and Migrants, the Comprehensive Refugee Response Framework and the two Global Compacts on refugees and for safe, orderly and regular migration.

on five priority areas: (1) learning the Greek language, (2) reception of newly arrived children with migrant background, (3) education and teachers' in-service training, (4) data collection and analysis of the needs of pupils with migrant background and (5) intercultural approach in the new curricula. The document also describes the current state of affairs regarding the integration of children with migrant background in the Cyprus Educational System as well as the teaching of Greek as a second language.

Furthermore, the MOECSY continues to implement an antiracist policy in all the public schools. The creation of a sensitization culture against racism and intolerance and the promotion of equality and respect is also an integral part of the Curricula of various subjects (e.g. History, Literature, Modern Greek Language, Religious Education).

What follows is the current state of affairs regarding the integration of children with migrant background, as well as the teaching of Greek as a second language in the Department of Secondary Education of MOECSY. To begin with a placement test examining the level of knowledge in the Greek language is distributed to children with migrant background in the beginning of the school year. Based on the score achieved at the test, students are classified to the levels A1 or A2 of the Common European Framework of Reference for the Languages. Placement tests on Maths, Biology, Physics and Chemistry are planned to be distributed starting 2021-2022, in order to identify student's background knowledge in these school subjects and consequently widen the primarily language-focused teaching support to include other competences and school subjects.

Currently, five different "Programs for the teaching of Greek as a second language" are running in secondary education schools and in State Institutes for Further Education: The intensive program in transitional classes, the program for the teaching of Greek as a second language, the Educational Program for Unaccompanied Minors / Applicants of International Protection in lyceums and technical schools, the program at the State Institutes for Further Education for Unaccompanied Minors / Applicants of International Protection, the program for the intensive teaching of Greek as a second language in lyceums.

Since September 2019, the various programmes for the teaching of Greek as a second language are operating in 45 schools. Most of the children with a migrant background are integrated in transitional classes (18 schools) for one or two years, depending on their level of knowledge of the Greek Language in accordance with the Common European Framework of Reference for the Languages. Moreover, "The programme for students with migrant background in Lyceums" is operated in two Lyceums namely Livadia Lyceum and Paloyriotissa

Lyceym.

In order to support and train educational staff in teaching Greek as a Second Language, teacher training occurs:

- *during programmed school visits by supportive educational staff,*
- *during afternoon and/ or morning seminars,*
- *during conferences,*
- *during distance learning seminars.*

All material from different trainings and guides is available online at the website of Cyprus Pedagogical Institute (CPI). More specifically a Moodle Learning Platform was set up at the CPI website since 2019, in order to support educators continuing training, facilitate networking among them, and help them better utilise existing teaching resources concerning the teaching of Greek as a second language.

Since 2019, an online platform for secondary schools was launched (on a pilot basis) by the Centre of Educational Research and Evaluation, in order to collect data concerning students profile (age, country of origin etc).

Lastly, it must be added that many schools with children with migrant background participate in the project “School and Social Inclusion Actions”. The implementation of this project aims to support the population living below the poverty line or being at risk of poverty and social exclusion. It also aims at ensuring social welfare and supporting financially the weaker groups of the population that are particularly affected by the economic crisis, reducing early school leaving, improving learning outcomes and reducing school failure and delinquency.

- Please briefly indicate measures adopted by national and local authorities to ensure refugees' and migrants' right to education (several items could be ticked/mentioned):

- ✓ Inclusion in mainstream education
- ✓ Provision of language courses

- ✓ Specific training for educational staff
- ✓ Initiatives addressing discrimination and promoting cultural diversity and mutual acceptance
- ✓ Alternative administrative procedure (placement tests, portfolio of evidence, etc.)
- ✓ Accelerated learning programs
- ✓ Non-formal and/or alternative education programs
- ✓ Financial support

Other innovative measures:

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Please briefly elaborate further on the measures taken:

III. Methods used to draw the attention of the various authorities in the country to the instruments and to remove the obstacles encountered

1. Challenges and obstacles

- 1.1 Please indicate and provide any information on the difficulties encountered in the process of implementing the key provisions of the Convention/Recommendation (including legal and practical obstacles) and on the main issues that need to be addressed for promoting further the right to education in your country (several items could be ticked/mentioned):

- ✓ Challenges related to equitable access and inclusion in education (such as poverty and socio-economic factors, cultural and traditional attitudes, remoteness, migration and displacement, etc.)

Migration is an issue of great importance for the European Union generally and for Cyprus particularly. The increasing trend in the numbers of immigrants that come to Cyprus has significant implications, since it must support children of immigrants to effectively adjust to the school environment and system and to respond to its demands. The role of the Ministry of Education, Culture, Sport and Youth is critical, since the educational system must respond to the challenge of migration and multiculturalism through appropriate policies and measures that will shape up a school environment of mutual understanding and respect of all cultures and ethnicities.

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- ☐ Challenges related to the quality of education (such as shortages of qualified, trained and motivated teaching staff, non-supportive or inadequate teaching and learning as well as school environment, etc.)

N/A

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- ☐ Challenges relating to the system and governance (such as budgetary constraints, lack or weakness of monitoring systems – including the lack of reliable data, absence of supportive/inconsistent/obsolete legal and policy environment, lack of involvement of relevant stakeholders and lack of cooperation/coordination at different levels, etc.)

N/A

- ☐ Other:

- 1.2 Please provide a brief assessment of the effectiveness of the methods introduced to remove the obstacles encountered:

The Ministry of Education, Culture, Sport and Youth is promoting various raising awareness activities on the principles of non-discrimination and equality of educational opportunities engaging all stakeholders. It should be underlined that MOECSY gives great emphasis on ensuring equal access to education for all children living on the island, taking into account that the right to education is safeguarded in the Republic's Constitution (Article 20). Towards this end, free and accessible education is offered to all pupils. Moreover, the equality of all the children enrolled in schools is guaranteed by the legislation. The new regulations for the operation of public secondary schools that were issued in February 2017 clearly state that any person or public authority involved in the interpretation or implementation of the regulations is obliged to refrain from "any discrimination based on race, color, gender, language, religion, political and other beliefs of the child or his/her parents or guardians, citizenship, ethnic or social origin, economic situation, disability, birth, sexual orientation or any other situation". Thus, any discriminatory attitudes against refugee and migrant children is strictly forbidden.

2. Awareness-raising

UNESCO governing bodies have underlined the need for awareness raising. Given the importance of normative action at the national level, wide dissemination of the Convention must be ensured, with the support of National Commissions for UNESCO.

- Have activities been carried out to draw the attention of the various authorities of the country to the Convention/Recommendation and their provisions about the right to education and to raise awareness of the principles of non-discrimination and equality of educational opportunities? (several items could be ticked/mentioned)

- ☐ Translation of the Convention/Recommendation into the national and possibly local languages
- ☒ Dissemination and advocacy of the core content of the Convention/Recommendation or the core principles of the right to education
- ☐ Increased public awareness through advocacy material on the Convention/Recommendation or the core principles of the right to education
- ☐ Activities undertaken or supported by the National Commission to promote non-discrimination and equality of educational opportunities and to foster debate on critical issues in relation to the rights enshrined in the instruments
- ☐ Other:

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